affairs (MHA). According to officials in the communications ministry, security assessments were "currently under way for all three licensed operators"—Starlink, Jio Satellite Communications and Bharti Airtel-backed OneWeb India—and they were "broadly at the same regulatory stage". Meanwhile, Amazon's Indian subsidiary, Kuiper Services India, which operates under the Amazon Leo brand, has also sought a satcom licence.

Starlink maintains that it has met the government's requirements. Speaking at the India Mobile Congress in New Delhi on October 7, Lauren Dreyer, SpaceX's vice-president for Starlink business operations, said the company had built 20 gateway sites across India (ground stations that connect its satellites to terrestrial networks), installed security "controls at every layer" and agreed to Indian user data remaining within the country. The MHA has not publicly detailed what remains unresolved.

Musk's accusations sit uneasily with the fact that India's two largest telecom operators have entered into agreements with Starlink. In March 2025, Jio and Bharti Airtel separately agreed to distribute its equipment and explore offering its services, subject to regulatory approvals. Jio Platforms MD Akash Ambani declined to comment directly on Musk's allegations, telling Business Today TV that Jio remained focused on delivering value to Indian consumers.

A LONG WAIT

Starlink's Indian ambitions date back to 2021. In November that year, it began accepting pre-orders before securing a licence. The government warned the public against subscribing, and the company subsequently refunded more than 5,000 bookings. It applied for a Global Mobile Personal Communication by Satellite (GMPCS) licence—to provide satcom services in India—next October. The policy debate soon shifted to spectrum. On October 15, 2024, the government opted to allocate satellite spectrum administratively rather than through an auction. Starlink had favoured this approach; Jio had argued for an auction.

The political context was also changing. In February 2025, during his visit to the US, Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Elon Musk in Washington, just weeks after Donald Trump began his second term and established the new Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE), which Musk had been tapped to lead. Modi's account of their meeting said they had discussed "space, mobility, technology and innovation". A month later, Jio and Airtel announced agreements to distribute Starlink equipment and explore its services in India, subject to regulatory approvals. Congress leader Jairam Ramesh questioned whether the deals had been orchestrated to "buy goodwill" with Trump and raised a national security concern: who would have the power to switch Starlink's connectivity on or off when required?

Starlink received its GMPCS licence in June 2025 and authorisation from India's space regulator, IN-SPACe, the following month. Trial spectrum followed in September. Yet the final steps towards commercial operations remained unfinished, as security agencies sought further information and assurances. This was also the period when Musk and Trump had a falling out, though the two patched up their differences later. Starlink's Indian subsidiary, wholly owned by SpaceX, is separately awaiting approval for its foreign investment.



"India does not allow a monopoly in any sector. Even in satcom, today there are three licensees. Once each one of these parties has fulfilled the requirements, they can start operations"

JYOTIRADITYA SCINDIA
Union Minister of Communications, at a media briefing, Oct. 9

The delay, however, has not been confined to Starlink. Jio Satellite Communications and OneWeb India have also been waiting to launch commercial services. At an October 9 media briefing, Scindia said the three parties could begin operations once the government finalised the spectrum usage charge framework and each of them had fulfilled the security requirements.

On October 14, Bharti Enterprises chairman Sunil Bharti Mittal weighed in, claiming OneWeb was "significantly ahead" of Starlink in the queue and he would be "very happy" to receive approval "even a few days before" Musk. Speaking at a Bloomberg event, he said OneWeb had applied five years ago, with its satellites already positioned over India and its ground network ready for three years.

The Digital Communications Commission has approved a spectrum

STARLINK

WHAT IS STARLINK

- A satellite internet service, operated by Elon Musk's SpaceX, that uses a constellation of satellites in Low Earth Orbit to beam internet directly to user terminals on the ground
- It aims to connect remote villages and border areas, besides ships and aircraft, where terrestrial networks are unavailable or unreliable
- In India, it is awaiting final clearances and spectrum allocation, alongside Jio Satellite Communications and Bharti-backed OneWeb India. Amazon Leo has also applied for a licence

165
Countries/ territories where Starlink is licensed

12
MILLION
Subscribers globally, as of Jun. 30